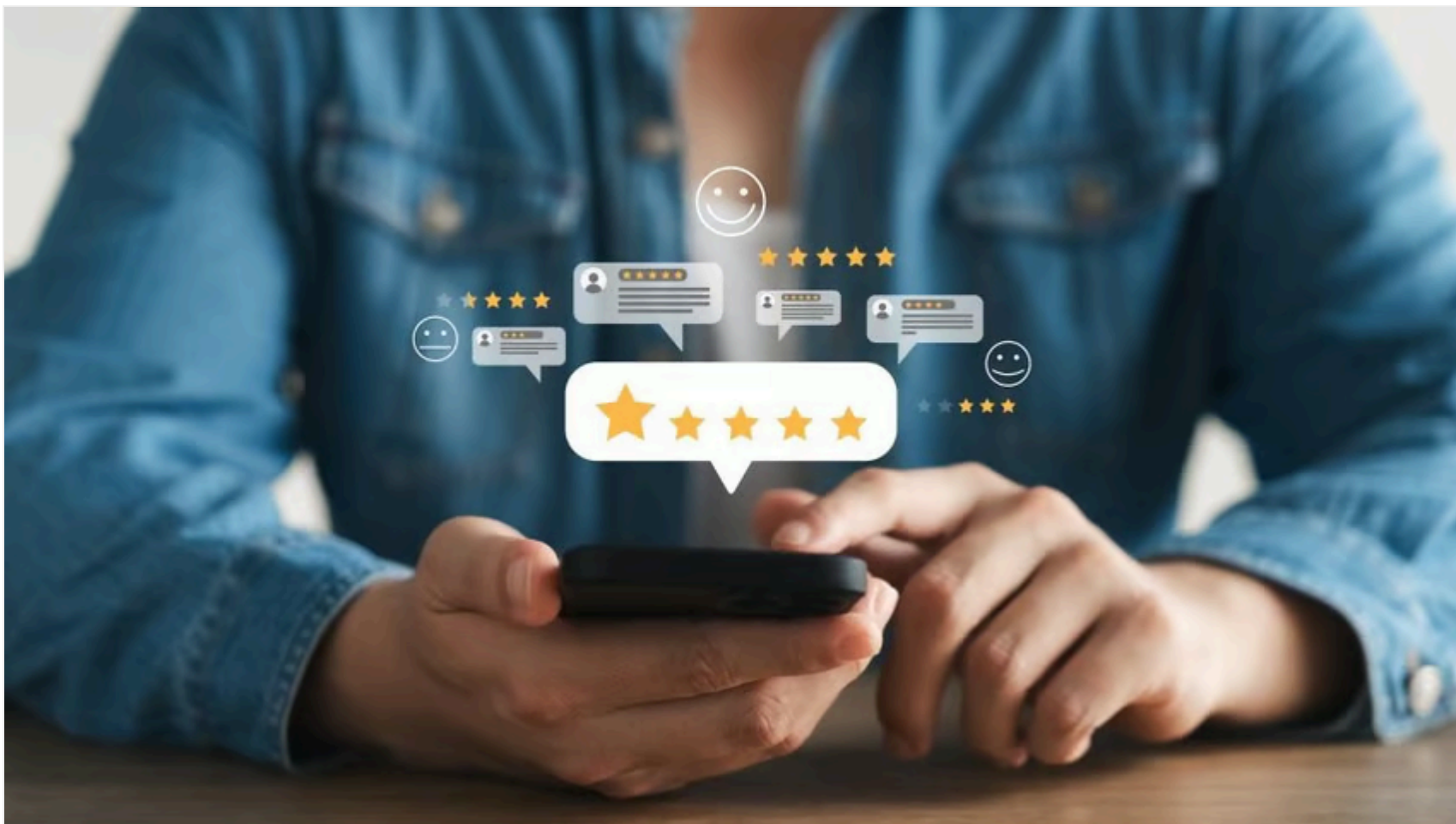


GUEST EXPERIENCE

Why Customer Feedback is Your Bar or Restaurant's Secret Weapon

By Elyse Glickman

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[Guest Feedback](#)[Guest experience](#)[customer experience](#)

(Photo: Thapana Onphalai, iStock / Getty Images Plus)

“Think of feedback as your secret ingredient,” says Michael Pavone, CEO of restaurant branding and marketing agency, Vigor. “Customer feedback is a goldmine if you know how to dig. Don’t ignore the value of data as it is the lens through which customer feedback becomes clear and actionable, revealing patterns and opportunities invisible to the naked eye. Every comment about a dish or drink is a free focus group telling you exactly what’s working, what’s not, and how to to innovate and refine your offerings.”

As Pavone will attest, a restaurant or bar’s reputation rises or falls based on how a customer is treated on his first or 100th visit. While [online review platforms \(https://www.barandrestaurant.com/operations/how-use-review-sites-bring-guests-your-bar\)](https://www.barandrestaurant.com/operations/how-use-review-sites-bring-guests-your-bar), and [social media \(https://www.barandrestaurant.com/marketing/how-expand-your-reach-social-media\)](https://www.barandrestaurant.com/marketing/how-expand-your-reach-social-media) can be a good barometer of how a venue is doing, keeping track of customer satisfaction through a mix of traditional and online channels is what may actually help the managers, culinary team, and servers think proactively and correct any mistakes that arise.

On the other hand, restaurant industry expert Geoffrey Toffetti finds that there are *too* many ways to collect information. The CEO of Frontline Performance Group (which operates the CheckMax platform, used to measure employee performance) observes many restaurants use just about every method available—from old school comment cards and suggestion boxes to QR codes, feedback via websites or apps, and platforms like Google, Yelp, OpenTable, and TripAdvisor. Conversations between customers, managers, and staff during a visit in real time has to be part of the mix.

“Restaurant managers end up with feedback scattered across 50 different channels,” points out Toffetti. “You can collect it, but how do you actually change the behavior of the person serving the guest? If a server’s performance is the issue, a ten-page report won’t fix it.”

According to Cyndee Harrison, co-founder of PR Shield (which promotes and protects business reputations), a restaurant’s reputation is measured in more than stars. Co-founder Rachael Amato advises PR Shield’s hospitality clients to “start human, and finish digital,” noting a mix of human connection and easy tech gives management real-time context.

“The numbers only matter if they lead to change,” Harrison says. “Management should have some form of simple weekly pulse-checks as we have for our hospitality clients. [Decision makers] and teams can track reviews and data over time, using them to spark conversations about what to improve next.”

By the Numbers

Bill Mitchell, CEO of HungerRush, is wholly invested in quantifying customer feedback to get numbers that add up to better-performing establishments. The veteran executive of several household name restaurants (Papa John’s, Dunkin’ Brands International, Cicis Pizza) found the numbers crunched out from a survey commissioned in September 2024 by HungerRush and conducted by Dynata, a first-party data company, to be most enlightening in terms of what drives customers to submit customer reviews.

Among the 1,000 U.S. consumers 18 years and older who participated:

- 80% of diners are more likely to visit a restaurant with positive reviews about food quality and taste.
- 77% of diners prefer restaurants with good service reviews.
- 63% of guests would avoid a restaurant with poor food quality reviews.
- 51% of diners shared a review about a restaurant in the past year.
- The top reasons customers leave negative reviews are poor service (57%), low food quality (28%), incorrect orders (26%), and high prices (20%).
- Positive reviews often mention great service (50%), delicious food (33%), discounts (31%), and consistent quality (22%).

By and For the People

Mitchell also believes in encouraging diners to give feedback directly to the restaurant and leave online reviews often gives the restaurants an opportunity to solve customer problems before they are publicly broadcast. Quick responses to feedback, whether it concerns service, food quality, or new technology like self-service ordering, are key to long-term success.

Along those lines, Christopher Ryan, Director of Food & Beverage at [Sheraton San Diego Resort](https://www.marriott.com/en-us/hotels/sansi-sheraton-san-diego-resort/overview/) (<https://www.marriott.com/en-us/hotels/sansi-sheraton-san-diego-resort/overview/>), says his property’s marketing team deployed personalized comment cards for all of its food and beverage outlets. The cards

include a QR code for both Yelp & TripAdvisor, and a space to add the team member's name. The team has also successfully tapped into the local neighborhood, built relationships with the concierge around the city, and reached out to local social clubs to drive business from neighboring hotels and residents.

“We use platforms like Revinate and Medallia to funnel up our reviews, but the front lines of our team are ultimately the eyes and ears of our operation,” Ryan explains. “Whether it's a technical issue in the kitchen or an unpopular dish, we usually hear about it from them, and aggregate those details to share with the larger group. We want to make sure our teams are as invested in the success of dishes and beverage offerings as any of our guests, which is why we include them during the menu tastings before we launch new items.”



Rumorosa restaurant within the Sheraton San Diego Resort. (Photo: Sheraton San Diego Resort)

In New York City, [Concord Hospitality](https://app.qwoted.com/companies/concord-hospitality/) (<https://app.qwoted.com/companies/concord-hospitality/>),’s mix of structured and informal methods includes digital guest surveys through platforms like Revinate and Yelp and real-time in-person engagement by its teams, according to [Dean Wendel](https://app.qwoted.com/sources/dean-wendel-f5ee450c-4478-4dcc-90c6-39eea93265b0) (<https://app.qwoted.com/sources/dean-wendel-f5ee450c-4478-4dcc-90c6-39eea93265b0>), Vice President, Food & Beverage. It also uses receipt QR code comment cards allowing guests to share input discreetly and at their convenience. Online review monitoring (Google, Yelp, OpenTable) is done daily to identify trends and flag any issues quickly.

“At one of our city-center restaurants, repeated guest feedback pointed to slow service during lunch,” says Wendel. “In response, we streamlined the menu, optimized kitchen production, and introduced a ‘Power Lunch’ option with a timed service guarantee. The result was a 15% increase in weekday lunch covers and a noticeable rise in repeat business from local professionals. Guest input validates and often inspires our innovation. We’ve hosted tasting panels with frequent diners when introducing new dishes or seasonal menus. Guest requests for more plant-based and gluten-free options, meanwhile, led us to develop several new menu offerings.”

In contrast, Chef Tyler Fenton, Founder and Head Chef at [Fentonelli's](https://fentonellisizzeria.com/) (<https://fentonellisizzeria.com/>) and [BATA](https://www.batatucson.com/) (<https://www.batatucson.com/>) in Tucson, stresses that real-time, in-person feedback provides the most valuable information. Some methods used to accomplish this include direct interaction with staff, suggestion boxes at the check-in desk, print comment cards, digital surveys via website or app, or surveys accessed with QR code via modern point-of-sale integration.

“We do not use Yelp or TripAdvisor on our website or marketing materials to draw new customers and encourage change,” Fenton says. “I know that it’s good for SEO, but it just never felt like it fits with any of our restaurants. Our website is our opportunity to tell our story exactly the way that we want to, and review platforms are where guests get to tell their side.”

[The Ra Ra Room \(https://therararoom.com/\)](https://therararoom.com/), a private dining experience, focuses on creating memorable experiences that compels members to share those moments with friends and encourage them to join.

“They make a significant investment in us, so we are always seeking to better understand their desires for the membership and always looking to add value,” says General Manager Jared LoPriore. “Our management reviews feedback and discusses key trends to ensure we are staying on the pulse of the room and focus on experiences that mean the most to our members.”

LoPriore says members of the “first-of-its-kind dining club in Phoenix, AZ” are encouraged to share their feedback so management and staff can better understand what they like and what they would like to see added or changed. One recent example of the members’ impact on its offerings involved special programming for Mother’s Day. Management decided to not only extend the hours, but also curate a menu and gifting experience to create a special memory for members and their families.



At The Ra Ra Room in Phoenix, management reviews feedback and discusses key trends to ensure they are focusing on experiences that mean the most to members. (Photo: The Ra Ra Room)

“We value in-person conversations with staff and managers, and we monitor social media messages,” says [Döner Haus \(https://doner.haus/\)](https://doner.haus/) Founder and CEO Nikolaus von Solodkoff, who says some of the most valuable feedback comes through direct email or its website contact form. “Email and website contact are the most effective because they allow us to respond personally and act quickly. In-person conversations are also highly effective because they allow for immediate solutions and relationship-building with our customers. We prefer these direct methods over feedback via third-party platforms, which are often less constructive and harder to act on.”



Putting Feedback to Work

How does one translate a comment into improvements and better customer satisfaction? “If three guests in a week say your flatbread is bland, that’s not a coincidence; that’s an action item,” explains Pavone. “When customers see you making changes based on their input, you’re not just improving your menu. You’re building loyalty. Successful restaurants that listen, adapt, and evolve are the ones that win.”

This is true across the board beyond food and beverage, from appealing décor to attentive staff performance. Wendel’s team tracks guest callouts of associates in reviews, and use that as part of an internal recognition programs. It boosts team morale and retention. Conversely, feedback around inconsistent service has helped his team refine the hiring profile, placing more emphasis on emotional intelligence and guest interaction in the front of house. Eye contact, engagement and anticipation of needs are a focus when speaking with potential associate.

“In one rooftop lounge, guests mentioned noise levels and uncomfortable seating in reviews,” says Wendel. “We added acoustic paneling and reconfigured the furniture layout. Post-renovation, our scores improved significantly, and we saw increased guest dwell time and higher average check totals. Lighting and sound are the two main areas of focus when defining a space, but your guest will often have a different opinion.”

Ryan, meanwhile, points to the feedback his team received from Brewery X Harbor Island from many customers about the lack of entrees on the menu. In response, the menu was expanded from handheld items to include full entrees. Based on customer feedback, the Bay Tower Lounge was completely re-conceived. While popular review platforms provided excellent insight, he feels the second most effective way to get customer feedback is through building relationships with regular customers to create strong word-of-mouth. He cites the examples of a local regular who was the first in line to buy eight tickets for an upcoming wine dinner and offering more seltzers around the property based on demand.

“We knew we wanted to pivot to a more lounge-focused experience and menu to fit the needs of the guests in both that section of the hotel and in downtown San Diego,” Ryan says. “That space, now called ‘Shorelight,’ is centered around an Italian-American concept and has a very appetizer-heavy menu, lending itself to visitors who want to try a little bit of everything. Bottom line; Give the people what they want.”

Every week, Döner Haus’ managers actively look for patterns that emerge from feedback from email, website contacts, and social media. Information is discussed in management meetings, with action items assigned.

“Nearly every meaningful menu or service change we make is driven by thoughtful, actionable feedback from guests who reach out directly,” von Solodkoff says. “We share positive comments with the team to recognize great work and keep morale high. We also made countless updates based on constructive guest feedback, including introducing a spicy sauce (we previously only had pepper flakes), adding baklava to the menu, and offering feta cheese as a topping.”

It may be a surprise to some that tip data is often left out of the feedback conversation, according to Toffetti, who finds it the clearest and most immediate indicators of customer satisfaction. “Tip percentages combined with check averages becomes a reliable proxy for both service quality and guest experience that can be measured in near real time,” he says. “It is a very effective way to gauge satisfaction that you can act on immediately. If someone leaves a small tip, you don’t need a survey to know they weren’t happy.”

Another issue Toffetti says CheckMax tackles is the effectiveness of [staff training](https://www.barandrestaurant.com/operations/restaurant-and-bar-safety-assess-potential-risks-implement-house-policies-train-staff) (<https://www.barandrestaurant.com/operations/restaurant-and-bar-safety-assess-potential-risks-implement-house-policies-train-staff>), particularly when new hires are often thrown “in the deep end” after just a couple

days of shadowing existing employees. “Nowhere are servers taught how to sell, be influential, or diffuse frustration,” he says. “They learn the menu but not the mindset of a guest. Small annoyances such as the frustration of an empty glass and a missing server can turn into lost revenue.”

[Loyalty programs \(https://www.barandrestaurant.com/marketing/key-ingredients-successful-loyalty-program\)](https://www.barandrestaurant.com/marketing/key-ingredients-successful-loyalty-program), meanwhile, can not only be a cash cow, but also a way to gauge the popularity of future events, menu changes, and promotions, according to Harrison. “Invite your VIP list to preview nights or special events and tell them exactly what feedback you want,” she suggests. “That simple loop builds community, fuels word-of-mouth, and reduces risk of expensive misfires.”

“We focus on truly knowing our members far beyond basic facts such as birthdays and anniversaries,” says The Ra Ra Room’s LoPriore. “Our location inside a sports and entertainment arena gives further insight into their interests, such as their preferred genre of music based on the concerts they attend at the arena. We learn their favorite cocktails, their children’s names, where they go to college, and important work accomplishments. By investing in those details, we build a foundation of trust that encourages honest feedback and allows us to continually refine and enhance the guest experience.”

The Sheraton San Diego Resort relies on members of its most loyal customer bases, including frequent business traveler guests and residents from the surrounding neighborhood frequenting the restaurants to provide honest feedback. Ryan observes those customers embrace having a say in future improvements and changes, which in turn, leads to continued positive word-of-mouth and valuable dialogue with management.

“When a guest says they don’t enjoy a dish in an online review, they aren’t telling you why,” Ryan explains. “Direct conversations with guests give us the chance to understand where they breakdown was and allow us to improve our offerings and put data trends together to improve dishes that have consistently been a topic of feedback.”

Speaking directly with Döner Haus staff or managers ensures that concerns and suggestions are heard and acted upon immediately. Von Solodkoff says these interactions also strengthens guest relationships and creates a more welcoming environment. “We value and appreciate positive public reviews on Yelp and TripAdvisor, but our focus is on personal connections with each guest,” he says. “When people take the time to tell us they love what we do, we keep that between us and them rather than using it as marketing material.”

“We are always listening to our guests to make sure we are delivering an experience that works for everyone,” insists Fenton. “We initially only served packaged beer at Fentonelli’s, but guests were regularly requesting draft, so we added a small draft system and now offer four draft beers. We make all of our operational decisions as a management team, which is usually our corporate team plus the management team for each location. Everyone in this group has different tastes, palates. Although we may (test new items)items with our staff if needed, we like to be nimble. If the management team is happy, we go live, and adjust as we go along.”



BATA restaurant in Tucson, Arizona gathers real-time, in-person feedback through direct interaction with staff, suggestion boxes at the check-in desk, printed comment cards, digital surveys via website or app, or surveys accessed with QR code. (Photo: BATA)

Looking Forward

“You can feature short guest quotes on your website, menus, and socials, and add a line about what you improved because of feedback,” says Amato. “Reviews are receipts for promises kept. Don’t just chase stars—highlight specifics that match your brand. When guests check in or share photos of their dining experience, reshare that content. Screenshot posts before they disappear in the timeline and replay them on your own social media and inside your venue—even on a bathroom digital screen cycling through customer sentiment. It shows you’re listening and inspires more guests to join the conversation.”

Positive reviews are used to build moral among the Sheraton San Diego’s employees. “Ultimately, if we can continue to recognize our associates for the great job they are doing, it's only going to continue to inspire them to put out a great product and provide the best service,” Ryan says. “We launched an internal recognition program earlier this year to honor any specific name mentions, from online reviews or reviews that come through our hospitality brand. This has directly led to an uptick in name usage across the property, and showcased the impact of what it means to engage personally with our guests.”

Should you consider bringing AI and other tools into monitoring customer satisfaction, Craig Guarraci, Tech PM Career Path, LLC founder, offers insight from 10 years of experience using AI to gain insight from tens of thousands of customer comment, and training AI/ML models to process customer feedback. Generative AI, such as Open AI ChatGPT, is particularly user friendly. The technology allows users to organize customer comments into categories like ‘service,’ ‘food,’ and ‘pricing,’ or separate sentences or phrases within customer comments into granular aspects of customers liked about a restaurant or bar (ex: ‘great service,’ ‘friendly service’) and areas for improvement (ex: ‘bland food,’ ‘watered down drinks’).

“A bar or restaurant owner/manager can include their customer feedback from social media and other [sources], and feed the feedback to Gen AI to organize,” Guarraci explains. “The restaurant owner/manager can ask repeated questions to Gen AI about that data and get suggestions to address issues as if interacting in real-time with a bar/restaurant expert consultant at a much cheaper rate. The Gen AI output can be a file easily opened in Excel, Google Sheets, or similar app to analyze further or visualize with charts to share with bar/restaurant staff.”

“A great table touch isn’t about hovering—it’s about closing the loop in real time,” affirms Amato. “We encourage leaders and operators to stop by [a table], ask one specific question, listen, and thank guests for feedback. If you end up fixing something before customers leave, you don’t just save the night, you often earn the glowing review. That’s the goal—service recovery and reputation management working together.”

A little extra effort can add up to major improvements and customer loyalty, according to Harrison. “A funny thing happens when you make asking and improving a habit—your community starts giving you more feedback, and they begin rooting for your success. When they see you’re really listening, they treat your growth like part of their job.”

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